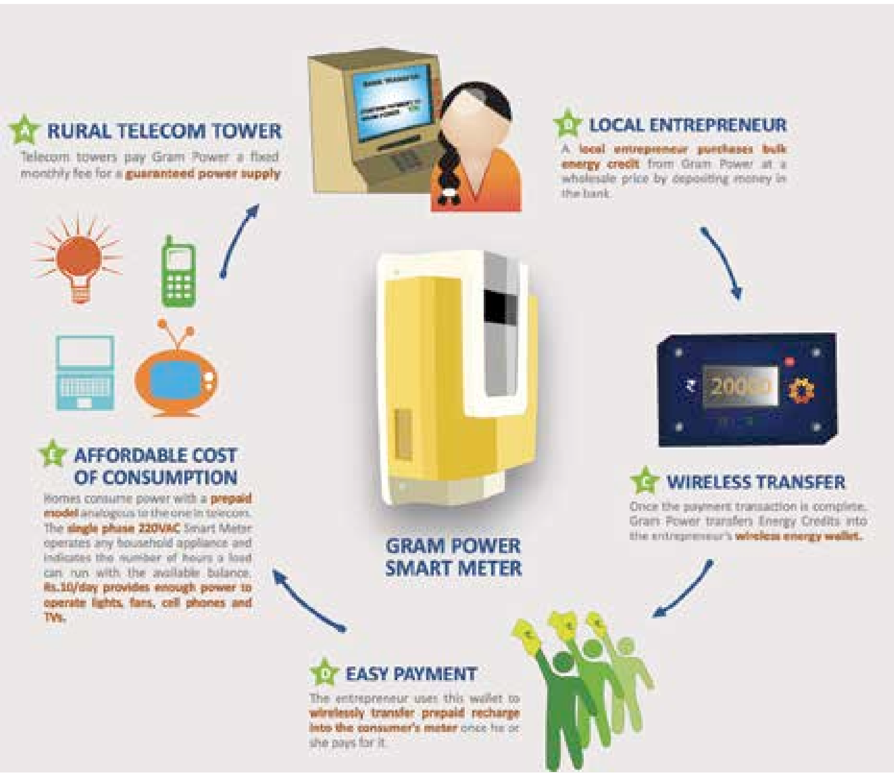
"The first such smart grid village in the country is something that we're currently negotiating with the government. It is going to be implemented in 2014 to be the first smart grid village in India. Once we prove what we are trying to prove with the technology and the business model, then of course we'll be scaling up in that sector predominantly."

when it comes to power consumption. Gram Power has received a lot of feedback from consumers similar to the manner in which they've been using their cell phones, because it's the exact same model. When asked about specific examples, Yashraj had this to say, "We've had instances where just by looking at the information that we display on our energy meters, we've had people who are switching to more efficient appliances. But then they keep comparing the numbers with their neighbours, and they'd be like, 'oh, they're using this appliance or this fan which is consuming only one rupee an hour while my fan is consuming four rupees an hour.' So they end up switching to the one rupee an hour fan."

Gram Power's also had consumers who look at the information from the meter, and they plan and purchase their entire monthly expenses on power. For instance, if they have to spend ₹400 per month, they know that they'll be able to use their light bulbs for X hours, operate the fan for Y hours and watch the TV for Z hours. Then they actually end up using their appliances for only those many hours so that they fall within their budget.



This infograph neatly explains how Gram Power operates. It's pretty much like recharging one's cell phone balance, that's how easy it is to top-up your electricity quota.

"These things are just not possible with the conventional system, because the conventional system is one cryptic thing," says Yashraj. "The consumers don't understand what that meter says or what the bill says. It just comes once in two months or once in five months and you just have to pay if you want to continue receiving electricity."

And the other thing that it does is that it makes power purchase extremely affordable for consumers. It's like a monetized power just like they purchase their daily quota of wheat and rice, or their daily quota of veggies from the local vendors. So there's a lot of advantages, a lot of behavioural changes that the model has proven. Of course the social impact of just electricity reaching areas that don't have it. That's of course very visible in all our work and systems. I mean there's a direct offset of kerosene powered lights, we've installed some systems in very remote forest areas where because of the absence of electricity wild animals used to eat up the cattle of the villagers. So that's stopped, now. Life no longer ends post-sunset. People actually gather in community areas and they're able to connect with the rest of the world through television and things like that. So, yeah, those things are definitely there.

Coming back to the original problem of electricity theft as the leading cause of unprecedented losses in the power sector, Gram Power's smart grid is capable of accurately identifying and isolating a wire or distribution cable which is tampered with on their grid, therefore effectively making the power theft problem a thing of the past.

Just think of all the money saved, money earned by state and power discoms. Something that'll definitely contribute towards the prosperity and development of India.